



Pygmies. All share a small stature and a profound knowledge of the rain forest—the most diverse habitat on Earth—from which they derive almost **everything** they need to live including food, building materials, and

medicine. Mbendjele are one such people. They **hunt and gather**, moving frequently from place to place within the forest so as not to exhaust it. There are also **settled** farmers living near their trading partners.

#### PREPARING FOR THE HUNT

A clan elder takes the gunpowder from a few bird-shot pellets and combines it to make a bullet big enough to kill a pig. Mbendjele people do not own guns, but they sometimes make deals with local people who do, borrowing a gun in return for a share of the kill. Pygmy people do not want to deplete the forest so they only kill large animals such as elephants or buffalos if there is an unusually big crowd of people to feed because of a funeral or celebration.



#### 1 A successful hunt

The Mbendjele are excellent hunters. This hunter returning to the camp is carrying two monkeys and a duiker (a kind of antelope) that he has killed.



#### 2 Sharing the kill

A big feast follows a successful hunt. The animals are quickly cut up and cooked so that everyone in the group can benefit from the nutritious meat.



#### 3 Cooking the meal

In the hot and steamy climate fresh meat, like this duiker head, soon spoils. One method of preservation is to smoke it over an open fire.



This sign means "gorilla." Mbendjele believe gorillas are reincarnated humans and never kill or eat them.

This sign means a hunter has spotted a chimpanzee.

